

Home page › sport › FC Bayern

Longing for the ten: the Toni Kroos case

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Soon side by side? Toni Kroos (right) and Philipp Lahm. © dpa

FC Bayern has already announced its first entry for the 2010/11 season. On loan Toni Kroos, 19, has to return to Munich in accordance with the contract. But the relationship between Jungstar and „property club “ is strained.

When Bayern entered the Hanover AWD Arena early Sunday evening, the fresh result of the Bundesliga afternoon game was emblazoned from the scoreboard: Bayer Leverkusen 4 – VfB Stuttgart 0. Lower Saxony's audience and the Munich curve made „Ooooh“, which sounded from one direction to be sensational, from the other to be dismayed. The stadium spokesman provided further facts about the figures: „The goals: three times Stefan Kießling, once Erun Derdiyok.“ What he did not say, but what the Bavarians learned later: Toni Kroos had once again made a strong game, with assists, post shots, many ideas. „Your“ Toni Kroos.

Two days earlier at the annual general meeting in Munich-Riem, CEO Karl-Heinz Rummenigge had proudly and categorically declared that „it was clear: Toni Kroos will Return to us in July “. This is a clear announcement – of the loan agreement concluded with Leverkusen that it would also allow the business to be extended. But the latest performance contributions convinced FC Bayern: Kroos could also do it for the record champions.

This insight comes as a surprise, because until recently Toni Kroos was an example that talent does not guarantee anything. When he was 15, FC Bayern had brought him from Hansa Rostock's youth. In 2007, when Ottmar Hitzfeld stepped in as head coach, he had Kroos, who had just turned 17, regularly train with the professionals. He would even have let him play (like Lars Ricken and Ibrahim Tanko, who were only marginally older in Dortmund) – but after two double years at FC Bayern it was not thought of licensing a youth player. In the 2007/08 season, Kroos officially moved up to the first team, had its first successes as a Joker – as in the UEFA Cup game in Belgrade when he prepared the goals for the 2-2 match.

But Uli Hoeneß, the manager, feared the counterproductive effects of hymns of praise. When the club's own internet television channel came up with the question of match winner Toni Kroos immediately after that game, he made the man round on the microphone: „punch free kicks in, we can do that too. Do you know who was a match winner? Lucio. Note one with asterisk. “ As long as he was not of legal age, Kroos had no interview ban on the club, and Kroos was also the best tournament player at the junior World Cup of his year. It was only when he was 18 that he was free to express himself –, but the worse times had already begun for him. The next coach, Jürgen Klinsmann, usually did not include Kroos in the squad, appeased with long-term perspectives and development concepts. The Kroos clan finally rebelled last winter. The father demanded approval (he even had his lawyer look through the passages for the „kicker “ interview), the junior traveled to the winter training camp in Dubai with a ribbon injury, which he sustained during a New Year's jogging ice sheet slip in Rostock wanted to have. At FC Bayern you frowned doubly. Hoeneß demanded in Dubai that the Kroos family should trust Bayern and not journalists, Toni should not go, basta. Nevertheless: on the last pusher (31. January 2008) the approval was granted for Leverkusen, the Renitenz of the Kroos Group had paid off. And since Toni's younger brother Felix rejected an offer from Munich, the relationship between Bavaria and the Kroos from

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It was only a good two months ago that Uli Hoeneß added again. After the 3-0 victory in the Champions League with Maccabi Haifa, he refused to praise the two-time goal scorer Thomas Müller – with reference to the Kroos case:

„Where is he today? “ But just since the new blame from Munich, Kroos ' has started a career. When Renato Augusto injured himself in Leverkusen, he joined the team. And now he's good. And confirms what DFB sports director Matthias Sammer says: „A young player absolutely needs regular training at a high level, he needs individualized training and he needs practice. “ Kroos now has all of this – and so the 19-year-old inevitably becomes a candidate who could still join the World Cup team.

That is the beautiful view. However, he obviously doesn't like the situation with Munich. Because with Leverkusen („ Here I have the pure desire for football “) and coach Jupp Heynckes („ I showed Toni his possibilities at the beginning of the season “) he found what he missed from Bavaria. „Everyone sees how comfortable Toni feels with us, he doesn't want to leave “, says Stefan Kießling. Kroos is currently displacing the topic of Munich return: „I am not interested in what is gone for months. “

Nobody wants to give advice, neither does DFB man Matthias Sammer. „You don't know what Bavaria is up to, whether they are ready to make Toni number 10. “ To the playmaker. The vacancy of Bavaria in this position is a topic of attraction among the fans; at the annual general meeting, a member went to the lectern and asked if one could hope to get a real ten again – „one that Real Madrid has with cocoa “.

President Uli Hoeneß replied that he affirmed that Kroos would be brought back – but he also suggested that it was not easy to play a system with offensive missiles like Ribery and Robben and one or two real storm peaks. Then a

director? „If we have five people on the pitch who don't do anything to the rear“, said Hoeneß, „that doesn't work either. “

The Kroos family will register every request to speak from Munich.

Günter Klein

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